Furthermore, the British politician did not speak any Persian, and had to use interpreters during his travels. This meant that, unlike the other renowned Persian scholar, E.G. Browne, who travelled for a year through the country engaging with people from all walks of life, Curzon remained largely isolated from the local people and their culture, his time being spent talking with merchants and officials.[103] His lack of contact with the masses during his time in Persia perhaps goes some way towards explaining why Curzon would fail to recognise the nationalist feelings and popular hostility towards foreign powers that would become crucial to Anglo-Persian relations after the First World War. In contrast, in 1918 when Browne proposed a 'five point plan' for improving Anglo-Persian relations, he was in much better position to gauge popular feeling in Persia at the time.[104] Nevertheless, whether he was really an 'expert' on this region of the world or not, these early years of travel and writing would provide Curzon with the belief that he always knew best when it came to Britain's Asian affairs, and would become his standard justification for advocating policies in the face of opposition from his colleagues.

Having formulated his ideas regarding Russia, India and their South Asian neighbours in his early years of travel and writing, Curzon would have to wait until he was thirty-nine to be able to put these thoughts into action. After gaining his laurels in government as under-secretary of state for India (1891–1892) and under-secretary of state for Foreign Affairs (1895–1898), Curzon achieved one of the central aims of his career, and was appointed viceroy of India in 1898. The position could not have been more suited for a man who combined dedication to the British imperial mission with a pomposity that positively revelled in the ceremony of the viceroyalty. Often seen as the most regal of viceroys,[105] Curzon's tenure in India was marked by a scale of pageantry not seen before, including, for example, 'the biggest show that India will ever have had' in the form of Edward VII's Coronation Durbar.[106] These distractions were not merely created for Curzon's indulgence, however, but were part of his strongly held belief that the 'Oriental mind' thrived on spectacle.[107] In his earlier travels Curzon had quickly discovered that appearances counted for much when it came to Asian rulers – hence the well-known tale of his wearing medals and decorations he had purchased from a costume shop when he had an audience with the emir of Afghanistan.[108] The reaction of the Times to